



Colour-Coded Sentence Progression

A Teacher's Reference Guide — Year 1 to Year 6

Walls court Farm Academy edition. The colour-coded sentence-progression framework and its Year 1–6 structure sequence are the work of **Jacobs Education** (Primary English Consultancy). This guide restates that framework in a cleaner, typeset layout for staff reference, alongside [the school's companion interactive tool](#).

Overview

REFERENCE GUIDE

This guide sets out a colour-coded approach to teaching sentence construction across Years 1–6, following the sentence-type progression set by the National Curriculum. Each part of a sentence — its subject, its verb, its object, and so on — is given a consistent colour and symbol, so that the same visual language carries through every year group, only growing more complex as pupils do.

The parts of a sentence used throughout this guide are: **who** (the subject — who or what the sentence is about), **doing** (the verb), **what** (the object), **where**, **when**, **how** (an adverb), **describe** (an adjective), an unlabelled diamond for **auxiliary and modal verbs** (is/was/has/might..., where the verb isn't itself the action), and three connecting parts: **co-ordinating** and **subordinating conjunctions**, and **relative clauses**.

A note on "who": the subject of a sentence isn't always a person — "the ball" is the subject of "The ball deflates." From Year 3 onwards, this guide labels the block **who (subject)** to make that explicit as pupils' grammatical vocabulary develops; Years 1–2 keep the simpler term "who" to match the concrete, person-icon-friendly language young children need.

This guide can be used flexibly: follow a class's own year-group table for whole-class teaching, or drop down to an earlier year's table to scaffold a pupil working below age-related expectations, or up to stretch one working ahead.

Colour Key

REFERENCE GUIDE

Every block in this guide uses one of the following eleven colours and symbols, consistently across all six years.



who (subject)



doing



**what
(object)**



where



when



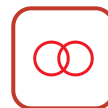
how



describe



**is / was /
has /
might...**



**co-
ordinating
conjunction**



**subordinating
conjunction**



**relative
clause**

Year 1

Year 1 pupils build a solid foundation in sentence construction: simple sentences with a subject (who) and a verb (doing), and joining words or clauses with 'and'.

Simple sentence

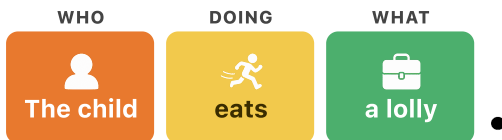
who + doing



The child eats.
The child ate.

Simple sentence

who + doing + what



The child eats a lolly.
The child ate a lolly.

Simple sentence

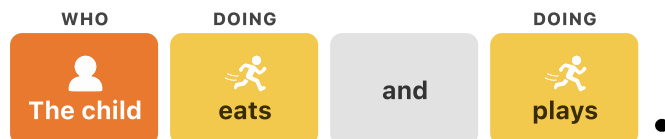
who + linking verb (is/was) + describe



The child is happy.
The child was happy.

Simple sentence using 'and'

who + doing + and + doing



The child eats and plays.
The child ate and played.

Simple sentence using 'and'

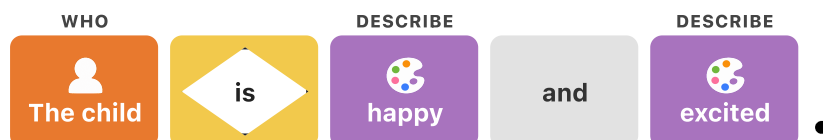
who + doing + what + and + what



The child eats the lolly and the fruit.
The child ate the lolly and the fruit.

Simple sentence using 'and'

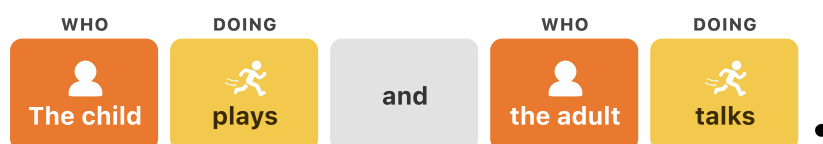
who + linking verb + describe + and + describe



The child is happy and excited.
The child was happy and excited.

Compound sentence using 'and'

Joining two main clauses: who + doing + and + who + doing



The child plays and the adult talks.
The child played and the adult talked.

Compound sentence using 'and'

Vary the structure, e.g. who + doing + what + and + who + doing

WHO	DOING	WHAT		WHO	DOING
 The child	 kicks	 the ball	and	 the adult	 watches

The child kicks the ball and the adult watches.
The child kicked the ball and the adult watched.

Year 2

Year 2 pupils expand sentences with adjectives and adverbs of manner ('how'), meet a wider range of co-ordinating conjunctions (but, so, or), start complex sentences with 'because', and use the progressive verb form.

Recap compound sentence

Co-ordinating conjunctions: and → but → so → or



The child cries so the adult helps them.
The child cried so the adult helped them.

Simple sentence with expanded noun phrase

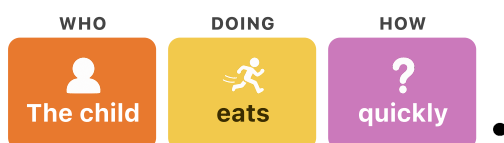
who + doing + describe + what (add commas for lists of adjectives when ready)



The child eats the delicious lolly.
The child ate the delicious lolly.

Simple sentence

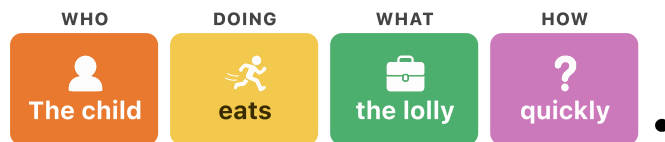
who + doing + how



The child eats quickly.
The child ate quickly.

Simple sentence

who + doing + what + how



The child eats the lolly quickly.
The child ate the lolly quickly.

Complex sentence using 'because'

Subordinating conjunctions: because → when → if → that



The child runs because they want the ball.
The child ran because they wanted the ball.

Simple progressive sentence

who + is/was (auxiliary) + doing (-ing form)



The child is eating.
The child was eating.

Year 3

Year 3 pupils recap and extend co-ordinating and subordinating conjunctions (yet, as, while, until, since), add 'where' and 'when' to simple sentences, and meet the present perfect verb form (has/have + past tense).

Recap compound sentence

Co-ordinating conjunctions and/but/so/or → introduce 'yet'



The child kicks the ball so the ball deflates.
The child kicked the ball so the ball deflated.

Recap complex sentence

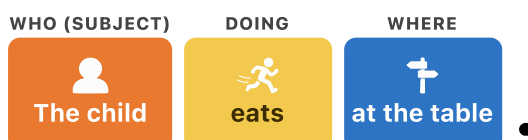
Subordinating conjunction 'because' → introduce as/while/until/since



The child eats while the adult reads a book.
The child ate while the adult read a book.

Simple sentence

who + doing + where



The child eats at the table.
The child ate at the table.

Simple sentence

who + doing + what + where

WHO (SUBJECT)



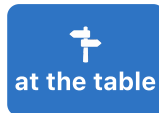
DOING



WHAT



WHERE



The child eats a lolly at the table.
The child ate a lolly at the table.

Simple sentence

who + doing + when

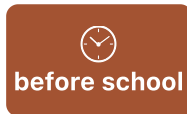
WHO (SUBJECT)



DOING



WHEN



The child eats before school.
The child ate before school.

Simple sentence

who + doing + what + when

WHO (SUBJECT)



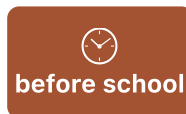
DOING



WHAT



WHEN



The child eats a lolly before school.
The child ate a lolly before school.

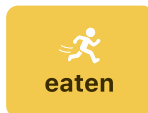
Simple present perfect sentence

who + has/have (auxiliary) + doing (past participle)

WHO (SUBJECT)



DOING



The child has eaten.
The children have eaten.

Year 4

Year 4 pupils recap complex sentences and add although/before/after, explore fronted adverbial phrases, move the subordinate clause to the start of a sentence, and expand noun phrases with extra nouns and prepositional phrases.

Recap complex sentence

Subordinating conjunctions from Y2/Y3 → introduce although/before/after



The child eats before the adult serves dinner.
The child ate before the adult served dinner.

Simple sentence with a fronted adverbial phrase

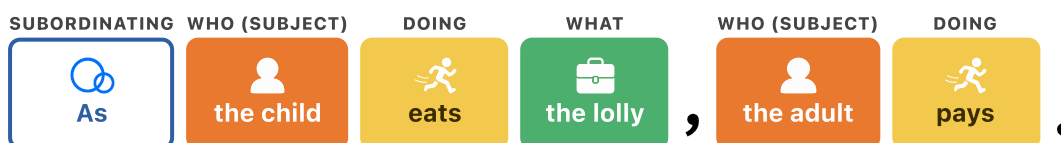
how / where / when + comma + who + doing + what



Before dinner, the child eats a lolly.
Before dinner, the child ate a lolly.

Complex sentence

Moving the subordinate clause to the beginning of the sentence



As the child eats the lolly, the adult pays.
As the child ate the lolly, the adult paid.

Simple sentence with noun phrase expanded by additional nouns

who + doing + what + what

WHO (SUBJECT)



DOING



WHAT



WHAT



.

The child eats an ice lolly.

The child ate an ice lolly.

Simple sentence with noun phrase expanded by a prepositional phrase

who + doing + what + where

WHO (SUBJECT)



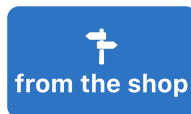
DOING



WHAT



WHERE



.

The child eats the lolly from the shop.

The child ate the lolly from the shop.

Year 5

Year 5 pupils widen their conjunction range further (for, unless, whenever, whereas), use adverbs of possibility, build modal-verb sentences, and learn to embed subordinate and relative clauses within a sentence — not just at the start or end.

Recap compound sentence

Co-ordinating conjunctions from previous years → introduce 'for'



The child eats for they are hungry.
The child ate for they were hungry.

Recap complex sentence

Subordinating conjunctions from Y2-Y4 → introduce unless/whenever/whereas



The child laughs whenever they hear a joke.
The child laughed whenever they heard a joke.

Simple sentence with an adverb for possibility

who + linking verb + adverb + describe



The child is completely overwhelmed.
The child was completely overwhelmed.

Simple modal sentence

who + modal verb + doing (+ what)

WHO (SUBJECT)



DOING



WHAT



.

The child might play football.
The child might play.

Complex sentence

Embed the subordinate clause within a sentence

WHO (SUBJECT)



,

SUBORDINATING



WHO (SUBJECT)



DOING



WHAT



,

DOING



.

The child, as the adult tells a joke, laughs.
The child, as the adult told a joke, laughed.

Complex sentence

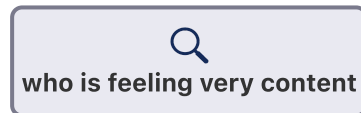
Embed a relative clause within a sentence

WHO (SUBJECT)



,

RELATIVE CLAUSE



,

DOING



WHAT



.

The child, who is feeling very content, eats their lolly.
The child, who was feeling very content, ate their lolly.

Complex sentence

Include a relative clause at the end of the sentence

WHO (SUBJECT)



DOING



WHAT



RELATIVE CLAUSE



.

The child eats the lolly that they won in a competition.
The child ate the lolly that they won in a competition.

Year 6

Year 6 pupils consolidate and refine advanced sentence structures: a final widening of subordinating conjunctions (in order to, provided that, supposing), and the passive voice, where the subject becomes the recipient of the action rather than the one doing it.

Recap complex sentence

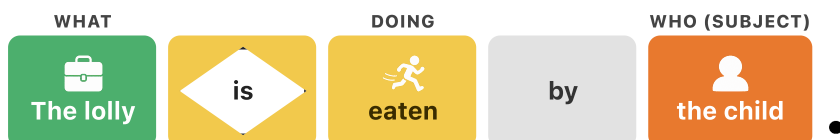
Subordinating conjunctions from Y2-Y5 → introduce in order to/provided that/supposing



The child smiles provided that the adult buys the lolly.
The child smiled provided that the adult bought the lolly.

Simple passive sentence

The object of the active sentence becomes the subject: what (as agent) + is/was + doing (past participle) + by + who



The lolly is eaten by the child.
The lolly was eaten by the child.

Grammatical terms used throughout this guide.

Adjective

A word that describes a noun (e.g., happy, red, tall).

Adverb

A word that modifies a verb, an adjective, or another adverb, often describing how, when, where, or to what extent something happens (e.g., quickly, yesterday, very).

Auxiliary Verb

A particular type of verb which is used alongside a main verb to form different tenses, moods, voices, or aspects.

Clause

A group of words containing a subject and a verb. Clauses can be independent (main clauses) or dependent (subordinate clauses).

Colourful Semantics

An approach that breaks down sentences into colour-coded components (e.g., who, doing, what, where). It helps pupils understand sentence structure by focusing on grammatical roles.

Complex Sentence

A sentence that includes one main clause and at least one subordinate clause, joined by a subordinating conjunction (e.g., because, when, although).

Compound Sentence

A sentence containing two or more main clauses joined by a co-ordinating conjunction (e.g., and, but, so).

Co-ordinating Conjunction

A word that joins two main clauses of equal importance (e.g., and, but, or, so). They are also used to link elements of equal grammatical importance (e.g., The child eats lollies and fruit.)

Fronted Adverbial

A word or phrase placed at the beginning of a sentence to describe the action that follows (e.g., Before dinner, the child ate a lolly.).

Main Clause

An independent clause that can stand alone as a complete sentence (e.g., The child eats the lolly.).

Modal Verbs

A specific type of auxiliary verb that express possibility, ability, permission, necessity, or obligation.

Noun Phrase

A phrase that includes a noun and any modifiers, such as adjectives or determiners (e.g., the big, red ball).

Passive Voice

A sentence structure where the subject is the recipient of the action rather than the object (e.g., The lolly was eaten by the child).

Preposition

A word that shows the relationship between a noun (or pronoun) and other words in a sentence. It often indicates direction, location, time, or how something is related to something else.

Prepositional Phrase

A phrase that begins with a preposition and modifies a noun or verb (e.g., on the table, under the bench).

Present Perfect Verb Form

A verb form which describes an action that is completed or linked to another time. It is formed with the auxiliary verb "to have" + the past participle of the main verb.

Progressive Verb Form

A verb form which describes an action that is ongoing or in progress. It is formed with the auxiliary verb "to be" + the -ing form (present participle) of the main verb.

Relative Clause

A type of subordinate clause introduced by a relative pronoun (who, which, that) that provides more information about a noun (e.g., The child, who was smiling, ate a lolly).

Sentence

A complete idea, usually containing a subject and a verb. In writing, sentences begin with a capital letter and end with a full stop, question mark, or exclamation mark.

Simple Sentence

A sentence that contains only one main clause (e.g., The child eats the lolly).

Subordinate Clause

A clause that depends on the main clause and cannot stand alone. Often introduced by subordinating conjunctions such as because, when, or if (e.g., because the child was hungry).

Subordinating Conjunction

A word or phrase that introduces a subordinate clause, linking it to the main clause (e.g., because, although, unless).

Verb

A word that describes an action, state, or occurrence (e.g., run, is, explains).

This is the full glossary from Jacobs Education's original document (Appendix 3), listed alphabetically here for ease of reference.